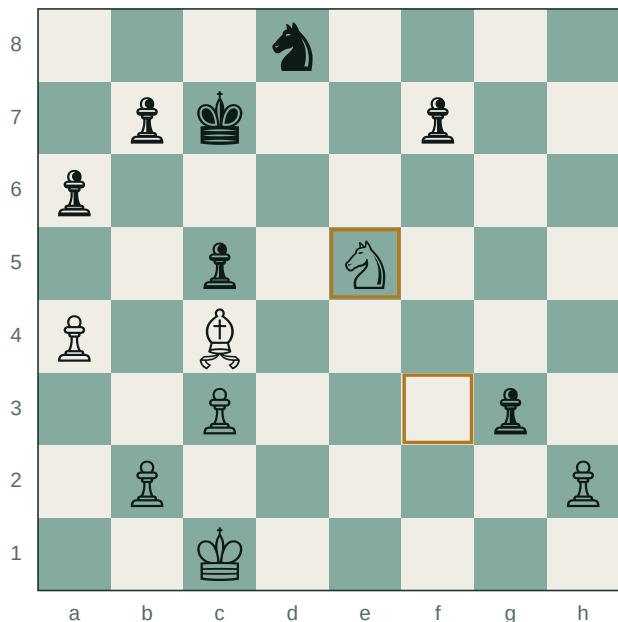


Advanced-pawn tactics: Black, move 26

Advanced-pawn tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Nxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...gxh2 27. Bd5 Kd6

26...gxh2 The pawn captures the pawn on h2. Recorded reply: **27.Bd5**.

27...Kd6 The king moves from c7 to d6. From d6 it attacks knight on e5 and bishop on d5.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 8 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -2 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A far-advanced pawn may be weak if unsupported. Check whether the opponent can capture it with tempo or blockade it permanently.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A pawn near promotion forces the defender to respect urgent threats. Its strength can create forks, deflections, or mating ideas even when it never actually promotes.

HOW TO LOOK

Count the remaining pushes and identify the blocker. Look for forcing moves that remove or distract that blocker.

The defending king is on c1. Geometrically undefended: knight on e5. Check for tactical protection.